PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #58 · PTSD

“When my body reacts, the danger is happening now. I am not safe even here.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

The body remembers. A smell, a tone of voice, a posture, or a sudden sensation can bring a wave of fear, numbness, or the urge to flee, even when the room is safe. That reaction is not you being dramatic. The lie is the interpretation: “Because my body reacts, the danger is happening now, and I am not safe even here.” A counselor can help you tell a memory in the body from a threat in the room, without making you relive anything. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

When anxiety overwhelms, God’s consolation is for the soul. He is a refuge and strength, an ever-present help. When you pass through deep waters, He is with you and they do not overwhelm you. He has not given a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control. Jesus gives peace and says not to let your heart be troubled. A reacting body is real. It is not, by itself, proof that the danger has returned or that this place is unsafe.

> *“When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul”* (Psalm 94:19).

Also see

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

> “When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze” (Isaiah 43:2).

> “For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control” (2 Timothy 1:7).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

Common self-statements

- It is happening again.
- I have to get out or I will not survive this feeling.
- If my heart is racing, I am in danger.
- I am not safe in my own home, my church, or my car.
- I should be over these reactions by now.
- God is far away when I feel like this.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Treating a body sensation as proof of present danger.
- Fortune telling: Deciding the feeling will not pass, or that harm is seconds away.
- Overgeneralization: Because the body reacts here, nowhere in the present is safe.
- Catastrophizing: Turning a wave of memory into a present emergency.

Challenging questions

- What year is it, and who is actually in the room?
- Is this sensation familiar from a memory rather than from what I see now?
- Has this wave passed before?
- What would my counselor tell me to do in the first minute?
- What is one thing I can touch or name that belongs to today?
- Where is God while this is loud, according to Scripture?

Truth summary

> My body can react to a memory without the danger being here now. I can be startled and still be safe, and God is with me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anxiety/Worry
- Fear
- Peace
- Trust
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Suffering
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
A body alarm can lie about what time it is.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
You can be held while your body remembers.

Worn — Tenth Avenue North
A worn-out body is not the same thing as a present danger.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
Christ meets you gently in the alarm. You do not have to be ashamed of it.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "When my body reacts, the danger is happening now. I am not safe even here."

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"When my body reacts, the danger is happening now. I am not safe even here." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What year is it, and who is actually in the room?
- ☐ Is this sensation familiar from a memory rather than from what I see now?
- ☐ Has this wave passed before?
- ☐ What would my counselor tell me to do in the first minute?
- ☐ What is one thing I can touch or name that belongs to today?
- ☐ Where is God while this is loud, according to Scripture?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My body can react to a memory without the danger being here now. I can be startled and still be safe, and God is with me.
- ☐ A body alarm is not a time machine.
- ☐ I can be triggered and still be in a safe room.
- ☐ God is a refuge while my body is loud.
- ☐ I do not have to explain the reaction in order to ride it out.
- ☐ This wave can peak and pass.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 94:19
  "When anxiety overwhelms me, Your consolation delights my soul."
- ☐ Psalm 46:1
  "God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."
- ☐ Isaiah 43:2
  "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ When your body said the danger was now: Each day, write down one moment when a reaction felt like the past had returned. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 94:19 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Anxiety is overwhelming me, and God's consolation is here. This is not the old danger.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Anxiety/Worry" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Orient to today. When a wave comes, name the date, the room, and one safe person, out loud if you can. Do not tell the story.
- ☐ Ride one wave with a plan you and your counselor already agreed on. If you do not have a plan, ask for one before you experiment.
- ☐ Note that it passed. Afterward, write only "It rose and it fell," not what you remembered.
- ☐ Do not face this alone. Tell your counselor how often the body alarm comes. Follow their pace.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "When my body reacts, the danger is happening now. I am not safe even here.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A body alarm that was not present danger
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~When my body reacts, the danger is happening now. I am not safe even here~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, my body says the danger is here. Console me. Help me know the difference between a memory and this room, and stay with me until the wave falls. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.